CANADA

DOCUMENTS RELATIFS AUX RELATIONS EXTÉRIEURES DU CANADA

DOCUMENTS ON CANADIAN EXTERNAL RELATIONS

VOLUME 17
1951

Compilé par/Edited by
Greg Donaghy

MINISTÈRE DES AFFAIRES ÉTRANGÈRES ET DU COMMERCE INTERNATIONAL
DEPARTMENT OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS AND INTERNATIONAL TRADE

3. If such three-cornered discussions are arranged, I assume that they will be kept entirely private and informal. Otherwise, of course, a number of other countries would consider, and with reason, that they had a good claim to be included.

4. The only difficulty I can foresee if we participate in such three-cornered discussions is that the Americans, after deferring to our wishes in some particulars, may consider that we are then under a moral obligation to support them in the United Nations and elsewhere, even though only some of our objections to their proposals may have been met. You may feel that this suspicion is unworthy and shows too cautious a determination to avoid commitments. My recent experience in New York, however, has convinced me that caution is necessary in any preliminary, informal talks. On several occasions after I had told the United States representatives there of my views on the United States resolution and when they had made a few changes in an effort to be conciliatory, I was confronted with the feeling that now I was expected to "lay Canadian support on the line" now that our objections had been met. Since our main objections had not been met, I found this method of doing business somewhat irritating. I therefore consider that if you participate in discussions with the Americans and the British, you should make it clear at the outset that, although we are more than willing to have a frank exchange of views with them on the course to be followed now that the People's Government has been formally condemned, we cannot regard ourselves as bound in any way by these discussions. Above all, you should tell them frankly that we are maintaining the right to determine our own attitude to whatever action may be proposed in the United Nations when the time comes to take such a decision.

5. I am looking forward to your visit to Ottawa which will give us a chance of thrashing out this whole question further.

81. DEA/50069-A-40

Le secrétaire d'État aux Affaires extérieures à l'ambassadeur aux États-Unis

Secretary of State for External Affairs to Ambassador in United States

DESPATCH Y-650 Ottawa, February 9, 1951

SECRET

Reference: My telegram No. EX-310 of February 9, 1951.

UNITED STATES FAR EASTERN POLICY

In view of the rapid drift in United States policy toward an irrevocable break with the Chinese Communists and of the danger of the United States adopting a policy of assisting the Chinese resistance movement on the mainland and of further rearming Chiang Kai-Shek, I think you should seek an early opportunity to discuss with the United States Government, at a high level, the long term objectives of their Far Eastern policy, in which we must inevitably be involved.

2. Since Mr. Acheson and other officials of the United States Government may feel that we have been giving them too much gratuitous advice lately on United States policy in the Far East, I do not think that at this stage we need to make suggestions to them on what their policy should be. You should instead do your best to draw them out. What follows in this despatch is material which I hope will be of use to you in doing this.

3. There may be some lessons to be drawn between our present position in relation to China and the situation which existed in 1939 when the Soviet Union attacked Finland. At that time it was plain that the Soviet attack was an outrageous betrayal of all the principles which underlay the international community and one had to define the Soviet action in those terms. Yet, it would have been disastrous if we had come into conflict with the Soviet Union over Finland, particularly when it was clear that the Soviet-German alliance was of the most opportunistic nature and that unless any precipitate action on our side had prevented it, these two powers were bound to fall out, thereby bringing Russian manpower to bear against Germany. The parallel obviously should not be pressed too far, especially since Sino-Soviet relations today are undoubtedly closer and more stable than Soviet-German relations in 1939-41. Nevertheless, the principle of keeping the eye on the main danger still holds good and any hostile action which we launch against China would only have the effect of strengthening the grip of the Communist regime upon the people on the one hand and increasing its dependence on the Soviet Government on the other.

4. Another instance of the wisdom of restraint can be adduced from the events in 1946 when the United States came very close to a break with Yugoslavia over the shooting down of a United States Army plane over that country. Precipitate action at that time might well have had the effect, if not of preventing, at least of postponing the breach between Tito and the Soviet Union.

5. We think it is now a fitting time to review the events leading up to the vote of January 30 and to frame a policy for the next stage. The main burden of responsibility for framing a constructive policy for that stage rests on the United States. It is therefore essential for us to know as precisely as we can what present United States objectives are as regards the Far East in general and China in particular.

6. The Canadian Government and people have, as you know, been deeply concerned during the past seven months over some aspects of United States Far Eastern policy. If a policy is coherent and logical, even if one disagrees with it, it may still command respect but some aspects of recent United States policy have seemed to us erratic and confused. At times it has been difficult for the Canadian Government to discover exactly what the current United States policy is. There have been occasions when, within a comparatively brief period, we have been given or have noted in the press statements by persons claiming to speak on behalf of the United States Government which have been conflicting or indeed contradictory. Dean Rusk has been wise and restrained but his expositions of United States policy have not always been consistent with public or private expositions by officers of equal or higher rank in the Administration, such as Hickerson, Gross or Austin. MacArthur's statements have, of course, added to the confusion.

7. This, plus outbursts of impatience and tactlessness, and the absence of any clear-cut sense of direction, both in the forming and carrying out of current United States policy, have, as you know, caused some differences between the United States and their Western allies. These differences are, however, even wider with certain Eastern governments, especially India.

8. I hope that we can now assume that the State Department has discarded all ideas of limited war with Communist China and that it may even share our doubts about the effectiveness and desirability of sanctions of any kind against China. We have never, however, so far as I am aware, been assured that Mr. Acheson has given up his advocacy of limited war. Even if ideas of limited war have been abandoned by the Administration, the outlines of an alternative United States policy have not yet emerged. I realize, of course, that this emergence is not going to be easy and will take some time. But I hope that the outlines of it will soon appear.

9. An alternative policy would have been to explore the possibilities of negotiation. The United States, however, not only pushed through the Assembly a resolution condemning China as an aggressor, but also gave the impression during the debate at Lake Success and even more in Washington that they were anxious to seize on the first Chinese reply to the statement of principles of January 27 as an excuse for withdrawing from their own commitment to those principles. One could only deduce from this that the United States had no real desire to enter into negotiations with China at that time.

10. We ourselves remained convinced throughout that negotiations with China should be our objective and condemnation voted only as a last resort. Nevertheless, in view of our recent experience at Lake Success we are not now prepared to lend our support to any plan for negotiations unless we are certain that the United States intends to work for their success. That is one reason why I did not accept the invitation to serve on the Good Offices Committee. It seems to me that it would be better to abandon for the immediate future all plans for negotiation than to enter into negotiations which are clearly foredoomed to failure. An early breakdown of negotiation, particularly if it arose from United States inflexibility or impatience, might finally convince the Chinese that their only hope lay in complete dependence on the Soviet Union. No doubt such a development would be welcomed in certain quarters in Peking and we should be careful not to facilitate it. I should think, therefore, that for the immediate future it might be wise to fall back, if possible, on diplomatic machinery outside the Good Offices Committee in an effort to bridge the gap between Washington and Peking. I doubt if the Good Offices Committee, tied up as it is with the resolution of condemnation, can do very much at this stage, though it may be very useful later.

11. It is important that we know what objectives the United States would seek in any negotiations. Would the United States subscribe to the following or would they suggest others:

(i) Localization of the war in Korea and, if possible its liquidation;

(ii) Prevention or postponement of Chinese Communist attacks on Indonesia, Malaya, Hong Kong, Burma, etc.;

(iii) As a corollary of the above, the retention of the access to areas of raw materials vital both to the West and to non-Communist Asian countries;

(iv) Agreement that our objective in the Far East is the defeat of aggression and not the use of the United Nations to overthrow Communist Governments;

(v) Elimination of the danger of our being drawn into a lengthy and perhaps indecisive military struggle with Chinese Communism when we have accepted the axiom that Western Europe should be the principal area of our defensive effort;

(vi) The desirability of doing everything possible to drive a wedge between Communist China and the U.S.S.R.; as a step towards this end, the opening up of China to our diplomatic and economic influences; and

(vii) Finally, and following from the above, stabilizing the Far East.

12. Even the partial achievement of these objectives would tend to strengthen friendly relations between the West and the non-Communist East which recent United States tactics have strained. The United States Administration must be aware that their recent policy has noticeably dismayed and vexed some of our potential friends in non-Communist Asia. Take the case of India, for example, the most important nation in this group. We think that India, though its reaction to Chinese intervention in Korea has seemed to the United States to be timid and wrong, has served as a useful channel of communication with Communist China and that we should look to the Indians for continued help if negotiations with China are to succeed. Yet the kind of misrepresentation of Indian motives given by Senator Austin in his speech of January 22 and the implicit threat of economic pressure made recently by Senator Connally will certainly not induce in India a spirit more co-operative with the aims of United States diplomacy.

13. We are, we hope, under no illusions about Mr. Nehru or Indian policy. We do not look upon the present Indian leadership as being the heir to all the Wisdom of the East, nor do we view all Indian proposals as realistic, as we showed by abstaining on the Asian resolution. At the same time, we believe that in the present circumstances we can hope for no more sympathetic or helpful administration in that country, which is still in a formative condition.

14. We consider that in the present lull in the diplomatic front it is up to the United States Government, following the vote of January 30, to indicate to countries such as Canada what they envisage as the next step and particularly whether they can hold out any positive hopes that negotiations with China will bear fruit. In entering such negotiations the United States would hold a comparatively favourable position. The chief factors in United States bargaining strength would include the following:

(i) The rapid increase of United States military strength, and the consequent shrinking of the military liability arising from the Korean operations;

(ii) The present United States control of Formosa;

(iii) The increasingly strong position of the United Nations forces in Korea and what appears to be now some strengthening of the French position in Indo-China;

(iv) The desire of the Chinese to participate in talks on the Japanese peace settlement;

(v) The desire of the Chinese Communist Government for recognition and entry into the United Nations; and

(vi) A factor on which there is still considerable doubt, the desire of Communist China, even at this late date, to avoid war with the United States.

15. In regard to point (vi) above, we would appreciate a State Department assessment on an important problem, which we feel is still unsolved, namely, the extent of Soviet influence on China, particularly on the conduct of the Korean aggression, and more generally, whether the Soviet Union is exercising a restraining hand upon Chinese Communist expansionist ambitions or pressing China forward. The answer to this, it seems to us, depends in large part on a calculation of the extent of the risks of a general war this year which the Soviet Union is prepared to run.

16. We are not blind to the powerful position which the Chinese would enjoy at a conference table as a result of their vast armies, their strategic location in regard to Korea and Indo-China and their backing by the military might of the Soviet Union. It seems to us, however, that the United States and Communist China through a realistic appraisal of both their own and others' strength could cautiously enter into a series of arrangements which would be in effect a wary and tortuous process of disengagement on both sides from the fixed positions in which each party has entrenched itself. If this process can only be commenced and followed up, even with all the disappointments and problems it would involve, we consider that it offers the only hope for a lessening of tensions and in the long run a comparative stabilization of the Far East. The chances of success of such negotiations, we realize, are slender. Chief among the difficulties, of course, are the fanatic marxist obsessions of Chinese Communist leaders and the excitable state of public opinion in the United States. Nevertheless, it is the task of diplomacy to pursue patiently and doggedly what appears to be the only sensible course.

17. During your discussions with the United States Government at a high level on the long term objectives of their policy in the Far East, I should be grateful if you would take advantage of any opportunity which presents itself to make clear that, while we have over the past seven months differed from the United States on their Far Eastern policy, and while we continue to have apprehensions about the drift of their policy in the Far East, the Canadian Government and people are fully conscious of the great debt of gratitude which they owe to the United States, and particularly to Mr. Truman and Mr. Acheson for the way in which they have, during the past seven months, rallied the whole of the free world to defend its common liberties against the increasing danger of Soviet aggression. Three years ago when the Communists seized Czechoslovakia, the United States and its fellow-members of the North Atlantic Community embarked on a process of strengthening their armed forces and their unity. Looking back at this period of the last three years, it is clear that up to the time of the attack on Korea last summer none of us in the North Atlantic Community was moving fast enough. The result, I am afraid, was that, instead of the gap between our strength and the Soviet strength narrowing, it was in fact widening and the inevitable result would have been disaster. This suicidal policy has been reversed because of United States leadership under Mr. Truman and Mr. Acheson, and latterly General Marshall. The United States has with

courage and imagination seized the opportunity which was presented by the developments in Korea to double and later to quadruple its defence effort and has carried its North Atlantic allies with it. The result is that for the first time since the end of hostilities there is good reason for believing that time is on our side and that if we continue with our present defence policies and pursue a patient, restrained and firm diplomacy, we may succeed in averting war and finally in reaching a tolerable *modus vivendi* with the Soviet Union.

L.B. PEARSON

82. DEA/50069-A-40

Le représentant permanent auprès des Nations Unies au secrétaire d'État aux Affaires extérieures

Permanent Representative to United Nations to Secretary of State for External Affairs

TELEGRAM 205 New York, February 12, 1951

SECRET. IMPORTANT.

Repeat Washington No. 138.
Reference paragraph 2 of my teletype No. 196† — Committee on Additional Measures for Korea.

1. Coulson of the United Kingdom delegation has today shown me copy of a telegram from London containing the instructions to the United Kingdom delegation regarding the study of sanctions against China by the Additional Measures Committee. You will no doubt have already received a copy of these instructions from Earnscliffe. Briefly they boil down to rejection by the United Kingdom Government of all the United States proposals for either economic or diplomatic sanctions against China by the United Nations.

2. So far as organization of the Committee on Additional Measures is concerned, I understand from Coulson that the United Kingdom now believe that Sarper or Muniz will be Chairman, with possibly Fawzi Bey or Gonzalez (Venezuela) as Vice-Chairman, and with Shann as rapporteur. The United Kingdom thinking is that once the bureau is formed, the Committee should adjourn for a period of perhaps three weeks while the bureau (not, repeat not, the Secretariat as mentioned in paragraph 2 of my teletype No. 196) prepares proposals for the Committee's consideration. During these three weeks it would be understood that the bureau would receive a good deal of guidance from the United States, United Kingdom and French delegations, and possibly ourselves, in order to ensure that the proposals when finally submitted to the Committee would be ones which the major contributing States had already agreed to.

3. In view of the fact that the United Kingdom and United States Governments are now so sharply divided regarding the question of sanctions, it seems to me that there might be something to be gained by trying to switch the emphasis in the Additional Measures Committee from the question of sanctions against China to